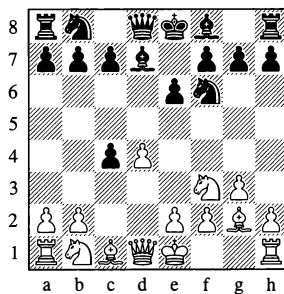


# Chapter 2

## Catalan



4...dxc4 and 5...♗d7

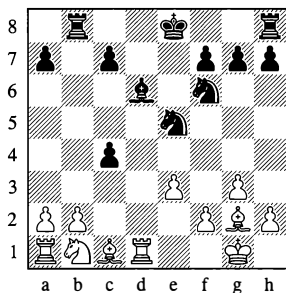
### Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♗g2 ♗d7

6.♘e5 ♗c6 7.♘xc6 ♘xc6 8.0-0

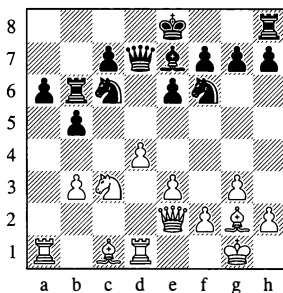
|                 |    |
|-----------------|----|
| A) 8...♗e7      | 26 |
| B) 8...♘d5!?    | 27 |
| C) 8...♖d7 9.e3 | 29 |
| C1) 9...♗b8     | 30 |
| C2) 9...0-0-0   | 31 |

C) note to 9.e3



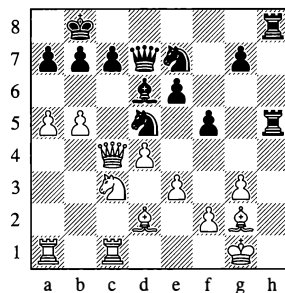
14.f4N

C1) after 14...♗e7



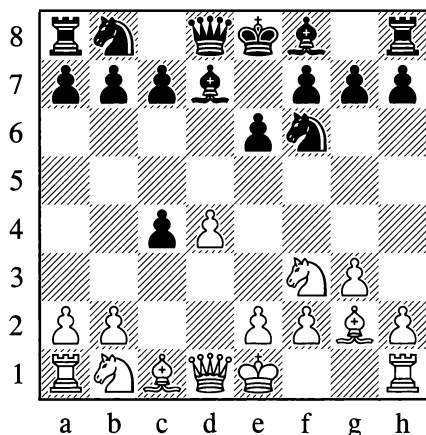
15.d5N

C2) after 19...♗dh8



20.a6!N

1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 ♙d7



I am quite surprised that this move remains fashionable. I assume that Black is excited at the prospect of queenside castling in the Catalan – and this is probably the only line where he can realize his dream!

### 6.♗e5

Definitely the most challenging move.

### 6...♙c6

The most popular continuation and a logical follow-up to Black's previous move.

Putting the other piece on c6 looks rather dubious:

6...♗c6 7.♗xc4

Black's light-squared bishop remains passive on d7.

7...♙b4†

Another line here is 7...♗d5 8.0-0 ♗b6, which occurred in Babik – Husson, Stockerau 1991. I believe the simple 9.b3N ♙e7 10.♗c3 0-0 11.♙b2 leads to a clear advantage for White.

8.♗c3 ♗d5 9.♙d3

Razuvaev's recommendation from *Chess Informant* 57 also looks very attractive: 9.0-0!? ♗xc3 (Much worse is 9...♙xc3

10.bxc3 ♗xc3 11.♙d3. White dominates with his bishop pair, while Black cannot even grab the d4-pawn: 11...♗xd4 12.♙e1! ♗dxe2† 13.♙xe2 ♗xe2† 14.♙xe2 0-0 15.♙a3 ♙e8 16.♙d1 ♙c8 17.♗a5 c6 18.♗c4!+–) 10.bxc3 ♙xc3 11.♙b1♞ 9...♙f6 10.e3

There is no point for White to enter the complications arising after: 10.a3?! ♗xd4 11.axb4 ♗xb4 12.♙b1 ♗bc2† 13.♗f1 ♗xa1 14.♙xa1 ♗b3∞ With mutual chances.

10...♙g6 11.♙e4

11.e4 is another strong possibility.

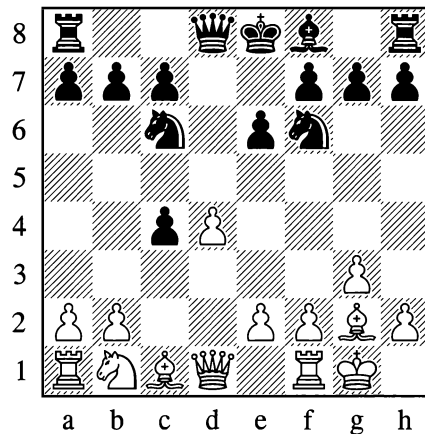
11...♙h5

This was Razuvaev – Klovans, Bern 1993, and here easiest is:

12.0-0N 0-0 13.a3 ♙e7 14.♙g2

With a pleasant edge for White.

### 7.♗xc6 ♗xc6 8.0-0

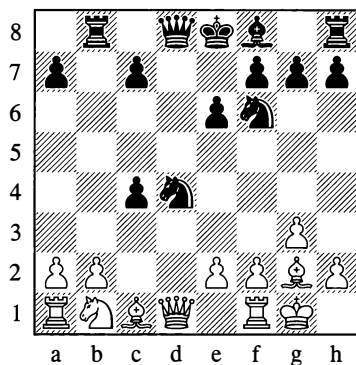


We have reached the first branching point. In this position Black has experimented with A) 8...♙e7 and B) 8...♗d5!?, but the main line continues to be C) 8...♙d7.

8...♗xd4?!

This has only occurred twice in practice, as Black quickly understood that his position was rather dubious after:

9.♙xb7 ♙b8 10.♙g2



10...Wd7

10...c5 11.d2 c3 (after 11...0-0 12.dxc4 White has a long-term advantage, thanks to his bishop pair and better pawn structure.) 12.bxc3 d5 13.Wc2± Black faced serious problems in Gulko – Korchnoi, Amsterdam 1989.

11.e3 d5

11...d5 12.Wc2 is also much better for White.

12.Wc2 Wb5 13.d2 d6 14.b3 cxb3?

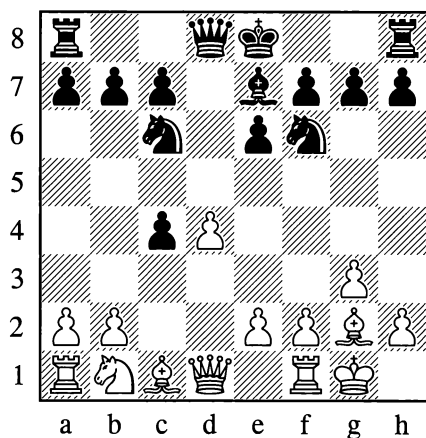
This happened in Tratar – Plesec, Slovenia 1994.

The lesser evil would be 14...e7, though White is clearly better after 15.bxc4 Wa6 16.c5 d5 17.d3 0-0 18.f3.

White could now grab a decisive advantage with:

15.c6†N d8 16.axb3

A) 8...e7



Once again White has a tough choice. Finally I decided to go with the following move:

9.Wa4

9.e3 seemed unclear to me after 9...e5! 10.dxc6† (the endgame arising after 10.dxe5 Wxd1 11.Wxd1 dxe5 12.xb7 Bb8 13.g2 0-0 is fine for Black due to his activity, as in Gyorkos – Farago, Zalakaros 1994) 10...bxc6 11.dxe5 Wxd1 12.fxd1 d4 (12...d7 13.d2! is better for White) 13.f4 c5 with sharp play in Kallai – Anka, Balatonbereny 1995.

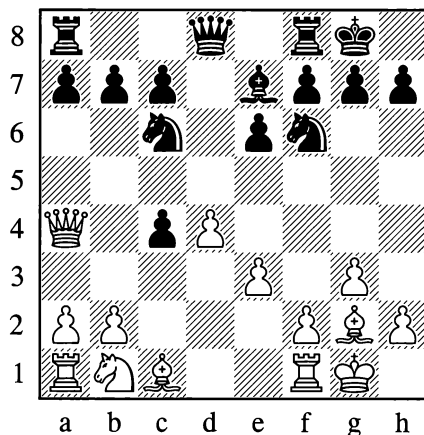
9...0-0

White is comfortably better after 9...Wd7 10.f3 0-0 11.d3 f8 12.Wxc4 with an obvious advantage, Johnson – Stracy, Dunedin 1999.

Unfortunately Black's try to complicate the game falls short: 10...0-0 11.d3 d5 12.Wxc4 d6 13.Wb5! with a nice refutation should Black take the central pawn: 13...dxd4 14.Wa5 b8 15.e3 d2† 16.f1 d5 17.dxd5 dxc1 18.fxc1 exd5 19.fxd5 d6 20.f5 b6 21.Wa6 Wc8 22.fxb6† Mate in two follows.

Or 10...d4 11.Wxd7† dxd7 12.d3± regaining the pawn with advantage.

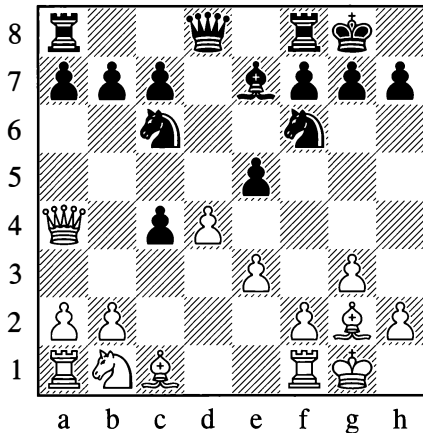
10.e3



**10...e5**

The move which I suggested for Black in *GM 1*.

White is obviously better after 10...♘b4 11.a3 ♘bd5 12.♙xc4± C. Horvath – Lukacs, Budapest 1994, or 10...a6 11.♙xc4± J. Horvath – Bokros, Szekszard 1996.

**11.♙d1!**

Other options are worse: 11.dxe5 ♘xe5 12.♙xb7 ♙b8 13.♙g2 ♙d7 with counterplay, or 11.♙xc6 bxc6 12.dxe5 ♘g4 with mutual chances.

**11...exd4**

After 11...♙c8 12.♙xc4 (There is no point in White giving up his light-squared bishop: 12.♙xc6?! bxc6 13.dxe5 ♘g4 14.f4 ♙e6 Black always will have plenty of counterplay against White's king.) 12...exd4 13.exd4 ♙d6 14.♘c3 White is better, thanks to his strong light-squared bishop.

**12.♙xc6**

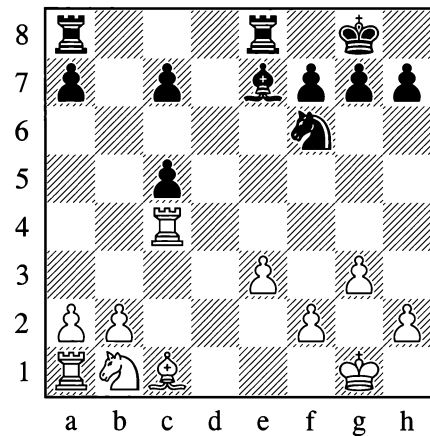
Black gets a solid position after 12.♙xc4 ♘d7! 13.exd4 ♘b6 14.♙f1 ♘b4! (14...♙f6 15.♘c3 ♙e7 16.♙e3± is better for White) 15.♘c3 c6 16.a3 ♘d4d5 17.♙d3 ♙e8 18.♙d2 ♙d7 and Black is close to equality.

**12...bxc6 13.♙xd4 ♙e8**

White looks better in every line:

13...♘d7 14.♙xc6 ♘e5 15.♙e4 ♙d6 16.♘d2 ♙e8 17.♙g2±

13...♙d6 14.♙xc6 ♙e7 15.♘d2 and White wins a pawn for nothing.

**14.♙xc4 c5 15.♙xe8 ♙fxe8****16.♘f1**

Less clear is 16.♘c3 ♙ed8 17.b3 ♘d7 with counterplay.

**16...♙ed8 17.♘e2 ♘d7 18.♙c2**

This endgame is quite unpleasant for Black:

**18...♘e5**

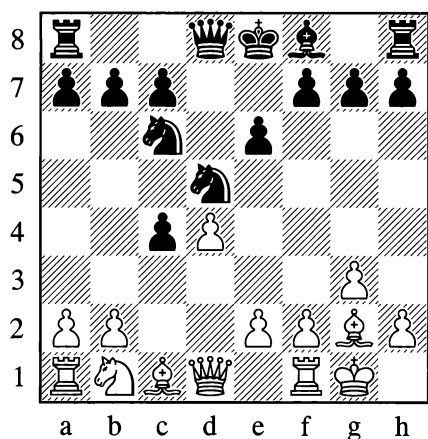
18...♘f8 19.♘a3 ♘e6 20.♘c4 with a clear advantage.

**19.♘a3 ♙ab8 20.♙d2**

Black is going to suffer for the rest of the game.

**B) 8...♘d5!?**

A playable alternative that has occurred several time in tournament practice.



### 9. ♖a4

I still like this move, despite the fact that White has lost both games in which it has been played.

### 9... ♗d6

9... ♗d7 10. ♖xc4 ♘b6 (10...0-0-0 11.e3 would just transpose to our main line) 11. ♗d3 0-0-0 12. ♖f3!± and White's light-squared bishop should secure him an advantage.

I also mentioned 9... ♘b6 10. ♗xc6† bxc6 11. ♖xc6† ♗d7 when White has a pleasant choice: 12. ♖xd7† (12. ♖f3 ♗e7 13. ♘c3 0-0 14. ♗d1± and White is slightly better, due to Black's damaged pawn structure on the queenside) 12... ♗xd7 13. e4± White's chances are slightly preferable in this endgame, thanks to his better pawn structure.

### 10. ♖xc4 ♗b4

The point of Black's idea.

### 11. ♖xb4N

This was also my recommendation in *GM 1*.

If 11. ♗xd5 exd5 12. ♖xd5 ♖xd4 White has nothing special, as in Sanchez Enriquez – Hernandez Carmenates, Merida 2011.

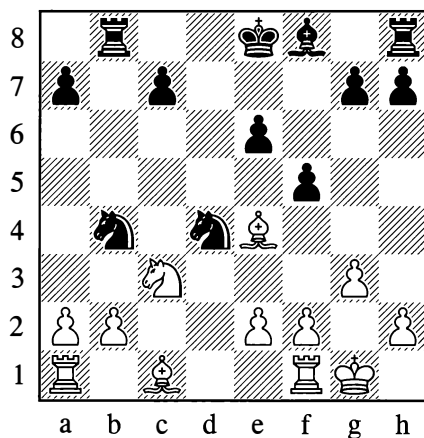
### 11... ♘dxb4 12. ♘c3 ♘xd4

After 12... ♘c2 13. d5! exd5 14. ♖b1 (less clear is 14. ♘xd5 0-0-0 14...0-0-0 (Black cannot play 14...d4?! 15. ♘b5 0-0-0 16. ♗f4 ♗d6 17. ♘xd6† cxd6 18. ♖fd1 and White will regain the d4-pawn with a clear advantage) 15. ♗xd5 White is better thanks to his pair of bishops.

### 13. ♗xb7 ♖b8 14. ♗e4

14. ♗g2 ♘bc2 15. ♖b1 ♗b4 with counterplay.

### 14...f5



### 15. ♗e3!

Only in this way can White fight for the advantage. Now Black has a choice:

### 15... ♘xe2†

This looks like Black's best option.

15...fxe4?! 16. ♗xd4 ♘c6 17. ♗e3 ♖xb2 18. ♖ab1 White will regain the e4-pawn, keeping an obvious advantage in the endgame due to his better pawn structure.

15... ♗c5 16. ♗b1! (16. ♖ad1 ♘xe2† 17. ♘xe2 ♗xe3 is equal) 16...0-0 (White is clearly better after 16... ♘d5 17. ♘xd5 exd5 18. ♗g2! ♖xb2 19. ♖d1 ♖b4 20. ♗xf5±) 17. ♖d1 ♖fd8 18. ♗g2 ♘bc6 19. ♗d3 and White is better thanks to his bishops.

**16.♟xe2 fxe4 17.♟c3**

Less convincing is 17.♙xa7 ♖b7 18.♙d4 ♟f7.

**17...♟d5 18.♙d4!**

Black comfortably equalizes after 18.♙xa7 ♖xb2 19.♟xe4 (19.♙d4 ♟f7 20.♟xd5 ♙d2=) followed by 20...♙a4.

**18...♟f6**

Or 18...♙b4 19.♙ad1 c5 20.♙e5 ♟b6 21.b3±.

**19.♙fe1 ♙b4 20.♙e3!**

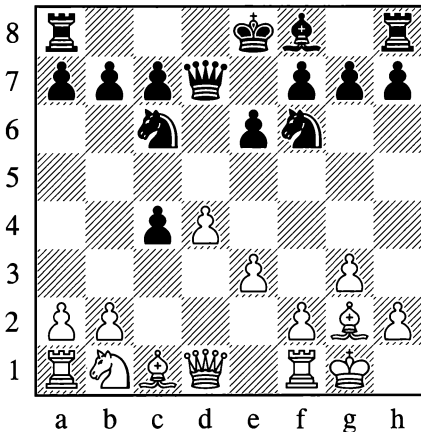
White has the better prospects.

**C) 8...♙d7**

This is Black's main continuation.

**9.e3**

According to the old theory Black equalizes after 9.♟c3 ♟xd4! 10.♙xb7 ♖b8 11.♙g2 ♙e7 12.e3 ♟b5! as in Yusupov – Karpov, Belfort 1988.



In *GM 1* I concentrated on **C1) 9...♙b8**, but now the main focus is on **C2) 9...0–0–0** as alluded to at the beginning of the chapter. There are, of course, several alternatives:

9...e5 10.dxe5 ♟xe5 11.♙xb7 ♖b8 12.♙g2 ♙xd1

If Black continues with 12...♙c5 White has another interesting idea: 13.b3!? 0–0 14.♙b2 ♖fd8 15.♙xd7 ♟fxd7 16.♟d2 cxb3 17.axb3 ♟d3 18.♙c3 White is clearly better.

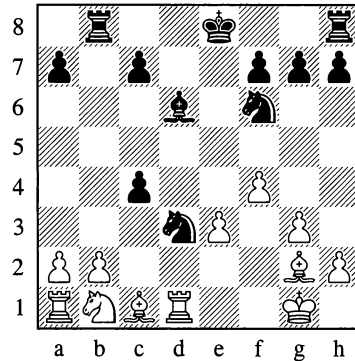
13.♙xd1 ♙d6

This was Cvitan – Vaganian, Neum 2000. White played 14.♟d2 and also achieved an advantage, but the following line looks even more convincing:

14.f4N ♟d3

14...♟ed7 15.♙f3! (with the idea of 16.e4)

15...♟c5 16.♟d2 and White wins a pawn.



15.♟d2! ♟xb2 16.♙xb2 ♖xb2 17.♟xc4 ♖c2 18.♟xd6† cxd6 19.♙xd6 ♟e7 20.♙a6±

With a technically winning position.

9...♟d5

This is met strongly by:

10.♟d2 h5

10...♟a5 has occurred in a few correspondence games, and in one of them White convincingly proved his advantage: 11.♙e2 ♙b5 12.♟f3 c6 13.e4 ♟f6 14.♙d1 c3 15.♙c2 cxb2 16.♙xb2 ♙c4 17.♙b1! White has more than enough compensation for a pawn, Cuccumini – V. Popov, corr. 2013.

11.♟xc4 h4 12.e4 ♟b6

This happened in Cheparinov – Grachev, Moscow 2011, and here I suggest the following improvement:

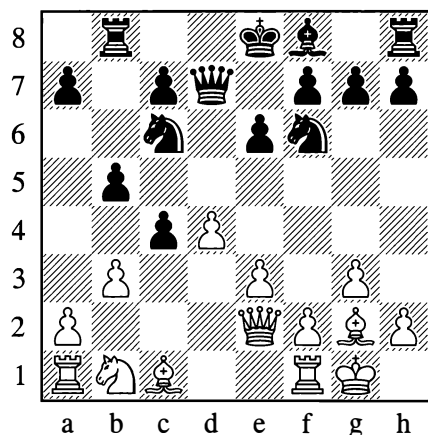
13. ♖xb6 N axb6 14. ♗e3

A logical sequence of moves is the following:  
14...0-0 15. ♖a4 ♖b8 16. ♗fd1 hxg3  
17. hxg3

It looks like Black has no play on the kingside, while White's positional advantage will tell in the long term.

17... ♗e7 18. ♗ac1 ♗f6 19. d5 ♖e5 20. ♖b3±

**C1) 9...♗b8 10.♖e2 b5 11.b3**



**11...cxb3**

Certainly not 11... ♖a5?! which runs into 12. ♗d2 b4 13. bxc4 with an advantage to White, Nesis – Engel, corr. 1988.

**12.axb3 ♗b6**

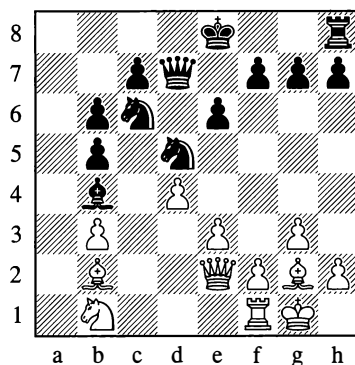
By far Black's most popular option.

12... ♗b4 13. ♗a6 ♖d5 14. ♗b2 ♗b6

I checked 14...0-0 15. e4 ♖f6 (15... ♖de7 16. d5↑ is just bad for Black) 16. d5 exd5 17. ♗xf6 gxf6 18. exd5 ♖e7 19. ♗xf6 when White has an obvious positional advantage.

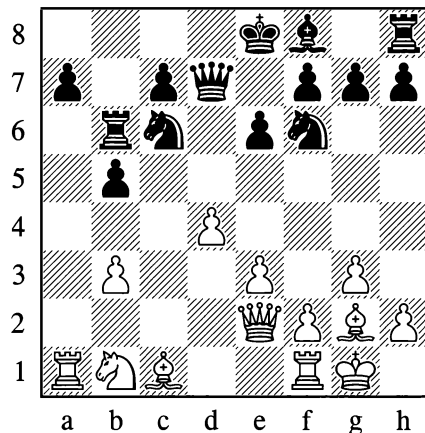
15. ♗xb6 axb6

This is definitely the stronger recapture. After 15...cxb6?! 16. e4 ♖f6 17. ♖xb5 ♗e7 as in Hofland – Westerman, corr. 1991, White could have decided the game on the spot: 18. ♗c1! N ♖a5 19. ♗c8+ ♗d8 20. ♖xd7+ ♖xd7 21. ♗a8 ♖xb3 22. ♗xa7+ ♗c7 23. d5+—



16. ♗xb5 ♖a5 17. ♗d3 0-0 18. e4 ♖f6 19. ♗d1±

White enjoys a pleasant Catalan edge, with the bishop pair and a strong centre.



**13. ♗d1**

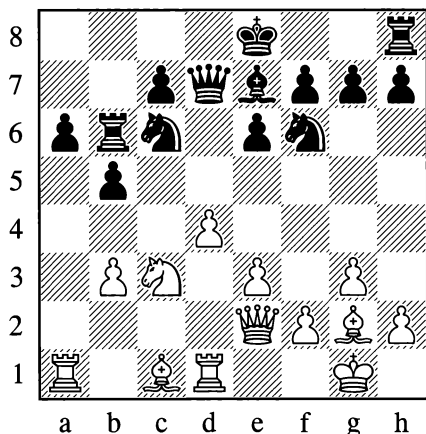
In *GM 1* I proposed 13. ♗xc6, but this time I would like to try something else.

**13...a6**

In the event of 13... ♗b4 14. ♗b2 0-0, White has the strong 15. d5! exd5 16. ♗xf6 gxf6 17. ♗xd5 ♖e6. Now in the game Gleizerov – C. Horvath, Budapest 1989, White could have played: 18. ♖c2N (threatening 19. ♗h5) 18... ♖e5 19. ♗xa7 With level material White's advantage is indisputable, due to Black's damaged structure on the kingside.

**14. ♖c3 ♗e7**

This has occurred in two games, but for some reason in both cases White refrained from the following tempting continuation:



15.d5 Nxd5 16.♘xd5 ♘xd5 17.♙xd5 ♙f6

I assume that White missed the following discovered attack while calculating on move 15:

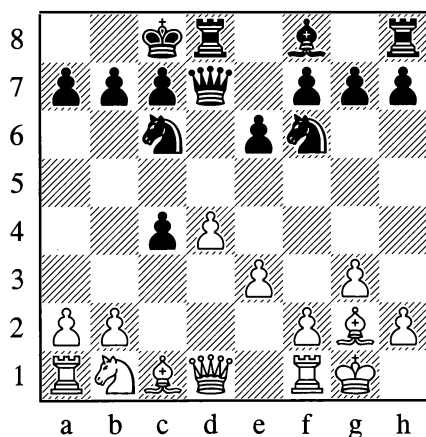
18.♙f3! ♙e6

18...♙e7 loses to 19.♙xa6 ♙xa6 20.♙xb5.

19.♙g4 ♙e7 20.♙d7† ♔f8 21.♙a3 b4  
22.♙b2 ♙xb2 23.♙xb2

With a pleasant advantage for White.

C2) 9...0-0-0



Currently the most fashionable continuation at grandmaster level.

10.♙a4

For a long time I had confidence in 10.♘d2, until I saw the game Giri – Harikrishna, Biel 2014, which continued 10...e5.

10...♘d5

10...h5

This has been tried a few times by Black, but it allows White an additional option:

11.♘d2

11.♙xc6 ♙xc6 12.♙xc6 bxc6 13.♘d2 h4  
14.♘xc4 ♙d6 15.♔g2 ♙h5 16.♙d2 ♙dh8 is surprisingly unclear.

11...♘d5 12.♘xc4 h4 13.♙d2 ♔b8

White was ready to launch an attack with 14.b4.

14.♙f1 f5 15.b4!

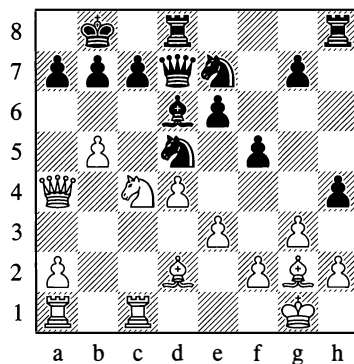
A thematic idea in this line. Accepting the pawn sacrifice with the Catalan bishop still in play looks suicidal.

15...♙d6

Apparently Black's best idea would have been 15...♘e5 16.♙xd7 ♘xd7 17.b5±, but White definitely has the better endgame with his bishop pair.

16.b5 ♘ce7

This happened in Stefanova – M. Socko, Warsaw 2013, and here the following idea looks very strong:



## 17. ♖b3N

Followed by pushing the a-pawn.

17... ♖g8 18. a4 ♖gf6 19. a5 hxg3 20. hxg3 g5  
21. b6 cxb6 22. ♖xb6!

White's attack will win the race.

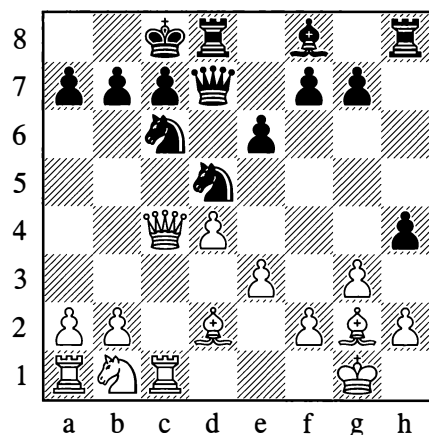
## 11. ♖xc4 h5

Obviously this is Black's key attacking idea, otherwise the whole strategy would be foolish.

## 12. ♔d2 h4 13. ♖c1

The last preparatory move before the real action begins!

An immediate 13. b4 seems premature in view of: 13... ♖cxb4! 14. ♔xb4 ♔xb4 15. e4 (15. ♔xd5? ♖xd5 16. ♖xb4 hxg3 and Black's attack decides) 15... ♖f4! 16. gxf4 ♖xd4 17. ♖xd4 ♖xd4 I am not sure White has anything here.



## 13...hxg3

13...f5 occurred in Rodshtein – Shyam, Benasque 2013, with Black obtaining a good game. However, after the thematic 14. b4N we would soon transpose into the main line.

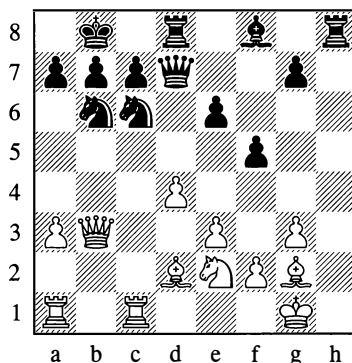
## 14. hxg3 f5 15. b4!

White has to start active play on the queenside in order to maximize his light-squared bishop's power. The only game here continued with:

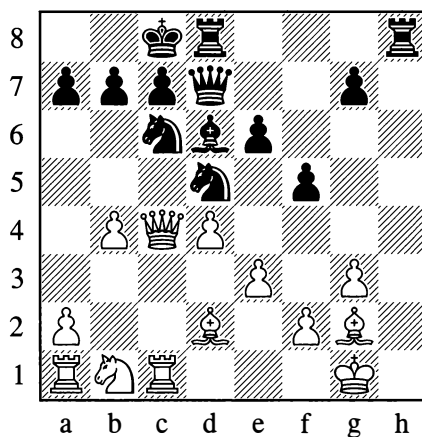
## 15...♔d6

15... ♔xb4 16. ♔xb4 ♖cxb4 17. ♖d2 will be too difficult for Black to defend. White has his Catalan bishop, a knight heading for c5 and open files for his rooks.

15... ♖cxb4 This seems to be critical, although White's position looks attractive after 16. a3 ♖c6 17. ♖c3 ♖b8 18. ♖b3 ♖b6 19. ♖e2. Here I developed the following line:



19...e5 20. ♖xc6! bxc6 21. a4 e4 22. a5 ♖h6 23. axb6 cxb6 24. f3! exf3 25. ♔xf3 g5 26. ♔g2± White's light-squared bishop should be an important factor to prove an advantage.



## 16. b5 ♖ce7 17. ♖c3 ♖b8

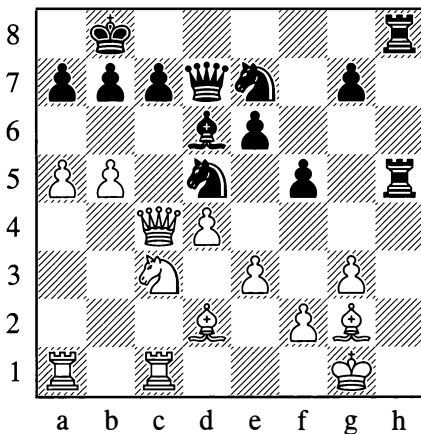
This is too slow.

Black should have tried 17... ♖xc3 18. ♖xc3

♘d5 19.♖b3 g5, although White can switch to a positional strategy: 20.e4! fxe4 21.♖e1 ♖h5 22.♙xe4 ♗dh8 23.♗e2 With a serious positional advantage.

#### 18.a4 ♖h5 19.a5 ♗dh8

This position occurred in Swinkels – Polaczek, Germany 2013. White has a few attacking ideas, with my preference being as follows:



#### 20.a6!N b6 21.e4 ♘xc3

21...fxe4 22.♘xe4 is clearly better for White.

#### 22.♖xc3 fxe4 23.♖e3 ♖xb5 24.♖xe4

Despite his extra pawn, Black's position is difficult. White will simply increase the pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

### Conclusion

The first part of the chapter shares many similarities with *GM 1*, with some general improvements added along the way. The overall assessment remains favourable for White.

After 5...♙d7 6.♘e5 ♙c6 7.♘xc6 ♘xc6 8.0–0 ♗d7 9.e3 the most critical test is now 9...0–0–0, which has recently been employed with increasing frequency at the top level. Black aims to launch a quick attack on the kingside, hoping to crash through before the rather unsafe position of his own king is exploited. White should be alert to the danger, but I am satisfied that my analysis shows how to maintain an initiative in all cases.